Current Affairs 03-11-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

Domicile-Based Reservations in Private Jobs

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For Prelims: Article 16 , **Article 371 ,** ***Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat*** , **Foreign Direct Investment , Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana** , **STRIVE** , **Inter-State Council**

For Mains: Fundamental Rights vis-à-vis State-Imposed Employment Restrictions, Regional Disparities in Employment and Inclusive Growth

Source: TH

Why in News?

The debate surrounding the **domicile-based job reservations** has recently regained national prominence. In October 2026, the Karnataka government initiated steps to revisit and reconsider the **Karnataka State Employment of Local Candidates in the Industries, Factories and Other Establishments Bill, 2024** , which had been temporarily shelved following industry backlash.

Summary

- The demand for local employment in the private sector reflects concerns over regional unemployment but raises constitutional, economic and labour mobility challenges, threatening India's integrated labour market.
- Balancing regional employment aspirations with national economic integration requires skill development, decentralised industrialisation, local entrepreneurship and cooperative federalism rather than rigid domicile-based quotas.

What are the Constitutional Provisions regarding Employment?

- **Article 14 (Equality before Law):** Reserving jobs exclusively for locals creates a geography-based classification that often fails the judicial test of **"intelligible differentia" and "reasonable classification."**

- **Article 15(1):** Prohibits the State from discriminating against any citizen on grounds only of religion, race, caste, sex, or **place of birth** .
- **Article 16(2) & 16(3) (Public Employment):** **Article 16(2)** strictly prohibits discrimination based on **residence or place of birth** in public employment.
  - The sole exception is **Article 16(3)** , which empowers **only the Parliament** (not State Legislatures) to enact laws prescribing residence as a condition for specific classes of employment.
- **Article 19(1)(d) & (e) (Right to Freedom of Movement & Residence):** Guarantees every citizen the fundamental right to move freely, reside, and settle in any part of the territory of India. **Domicile quotas** **act as a direct deterrent to this freedom.**
- **Article 19(1)(g) (Freedom of Profession):** Grants citizens the right to practice any profession or carry on any occupation, trade, or business.
  - Mandating hiring quotas is an unreasonable restriction on an employer's fundamental right to hire based on merit.
- **Article 371 (Special Provisions):** In certain exceptional cases (like **Article 371D** for Andhra Pradesh and Telangana), the Constitution provides **special safeguards for local cadres in public employment** , but this requires **Presidential intervention and is an exception, not the rule.**

What are the Arguments Regarding Domicile-Based Reservations?

Arguments For

- **Land Alienation and Rehabilitation:** Private industries are often set up on land acquired from local farmers. Proponents argue that industries have a moral and socio-economic obligation to **provide livelihoods to the native population displaced by such industrialization.**
- **Protection from Wage Suppression:** Migrant workers, often lacking social security, are desperate and willing to work in exploitative conditions below statutory minimum wages.
  - This deliberate undercutting forces local youth who demand fair wages and better conditions out of the market.
- **Curbing Agrarian Distress & Jobless Growth:** With agriculture becoming unviable, rural youth are migrating to urban centers.
  - States face immense democratic pressure to secure manufacturing and service sector jobs for these local youth to prevent regional poverty and social unrest.
- **Easing Strain on Mega-Cities:** Unchecked inter-state migration places an unsustainable burden on the housing, transport, and public health infrastructure of metropolitan hubs (e.g., Bengaluru, Gurugram).
  - Quotas act as a regulatory valve to manage demographic influxes.
- **Cultural and Linguistic Efficiency:** In service-oriented sectors (hospitality, retail, gig economy), hiring locals ensures proficiency in the regional language, fostering better customer relations and mitigating socio-political friction between natives and migrants.

Arguments Against

- **Balkanization of the Republic:** In the landmark ***Dr. Pradeep Jain v. Union of India (1984)*** **case** , the Supreme Court ruled that India recognizes only a **single Indian domicile** .

- State-level protectionism promotes regional chauvinism, undermining national integration and the ethos of ***"Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat" .***

- **The "Domino Effect" (Retaliatory Protectionism):** If one state successfully implements local quotas, it triggers a chain reaction.
  - In **IMT Industrial Association v. State of Haryana (2023)** , the Punjab and Haryana High Court struck down **Haryana's 75% private-sector reservation law,** warning that such laws create "artificial walls" across India.
  - Replication of private local quotas across states could cause a c **omplete breakdown of India's labour market** and demographic dividend by restricting labour mobility and fragmenting the national workforce.
- **Erosion of 'Ease of Doing Business':** Mandating strict quotas **overrides meritocracy** . It introduces heavy compliance burdens, bureaucratic red tape, and the **return of the 'Inspector Raj' in human resources** , infringing on corporate operational autonomy.
- **Skill Deficit and Capital Flight:** Industries require specific technical skills that may not be available locally. Forcing companies to hire unskilled locals damages global competitiveness.
  - Consequently, **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)** and domestic capital will relocate to states with flexible labor laws.
- **Constitutional Overreach:** State legislatures lack the constitutional competence to dictate private hiring based on domicile.
  - Attempting to bypass Article 16 by enforcing quotas in the private sector is seen as a **colorable exercise of power** (doing indirectly what cannot be done directly).

What Measures are Needed to Sustainably Address Regional Unemployment?

- **Fiscal Nudging:** Drawing on **NITI Aayog's Strategy for New India @ 75 (2018)** emphasis on employment generation and industrial growth, states could offer **performance-linked fiscal incentives** , such as additional subsidies or tax benefits, to industries that voluntarily hire and train local workers, promoting regional employment without imposing rigid domicile-based quotas.
  - This mirrors the **United States' "Opportunity Zones" (2017)** , which offers tax incentives for generating employment in distressed regions.
- **Aggressive Human Capital Investment:** To bridge the "employability gap", states must implement the **K. Kasturirangan Committee's (NEP 2020)** recommendation to integrate vocational education early.
  - India should emulate **Germany's Dual Vocational Training System** , scaling up schemes like **Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY)** and the World Bank-assisted **STRIVE** to create an industry-ready local workforce.
- **Decentralized Industrialization:** Emphasize "Spatial Development" to prevent the hyper-concentration of jobs.
  - States must decentralize job creation through the **One District One Product (ODOP)** and the **Shyama Prasad Mukherji Rurban Mission** , shifting industrial corridors to Tier-2/3 cities to organically retain local talent.
- **Fostering Local Entrepreneurship:** The **Global Entrepreneurship Monitor (GEM) Report** highlights the need to shift from "job seekers" to "job creators."
  - States should leverage the **PM Vishwakarma Scheme** and **MUDRA Yojana** to formalize traditional

artisans and fund local MSMEs, creating indigenous economic engines that naturally employ regional youth.

- **Activating Cooperative Federalism:** The **Punchhi Commission on Centre-State Relations (2010)** recommended active utilization of the **Inter-State Council (Article 263)** to resolve socio-economic frictions.
  - A national consensus must be built to ensure state-level employment policies do not fracture India's unified demographic dividend and labor market.

Conclusion

While prioritising local employment is legitimate, rigid domicile-based reservations in the private sector risk constitutional challenges and discourage investment. Skill development, decentralised industrialisation, and cooperative federalism offer sustainable solutions that balance regional development with India's integrated economic growth.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> The right to equality and freedom of movement are essential pillars of India's integrated labour market. Discuss how domicile-based employment restrictions challenge these constitutional principles.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What constitutional provisions govern domicile-based employment reservations?
Articles 14, 15, 16 and 19 protect equality, prohibit specified forms of discrimination and guarantee freedom of movement, residence and occupation. Article 16(3) empowers Parliament to prescribe residence requirements for certain public employment.

2. What did the Supreme Court rule in Dr. Pradeep Jain v. Union of India (1984)?
The Supreme Court emphasised the concept of a single Indian domicile and cautioned against excessive residence-based preferences that could undermine national integration.

3. What was the significance of IMT Industrial Association v. State of Haryana (2023)?
The Punjab and Haryana High Court struck down Haryana's 75% private-sector reservation law, highlighting its constitutional infirmities and warning against creating artificial walls between states.

4. What is Article 371D of the Constitution?
Article 371D provides special arrangements for equitable opportunities in public employment and education in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, through constitutionally prescribed mechanisms.

5. What are the key alternatives to domicile-based job reservations?
Skill development through PMKVY 4.0, decentralised industrialisation through ODOP, local entrepreneurship through MUDRA and PM Vishwakarma, and cooperative federalism can promote sustainable regional employment.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/NBqPWkBtEZo]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements: (2023)

Statement-I: The Supreme Court of India has held in some judgements that the reservation policies made under Article 16(4) of the Constitution of India would be limited by Article 335 for maintenance of efficiency of administration.

Statement-II: Article 335 of the Constitution of India defines the term ‘efficiency of administration.’

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(A) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is the correct explanation for Statement-I.

(B) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is not the correct explanation for Statement-I.

(C) Statement-I is correct but Statement-II is incorrect.

(D) Statement-I is incorrect but Statement-II is correct.

Ans: C

Mains

Q. Whether the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC) can enforce the implementation of constitutional reservation for the Scheduled Castes in the religious minority institutions? Examine. **(2018)**

Rashtriya Ekta Diwas 2026

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Source: AIR

Why in News?

Prime Minister paid tribute to **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel** at the Statue of Unity in Ekta Nagar, Gujarat, on his 151st birth anniversary (31st October 2026) and inaugurated Bharat Parv 2026, celebrating India's cultural diversity under the theme Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat.

What are the Key Facts About Rashtriya Ekta

Diwas (National Unity Day)?

- **About:** Rashtriya Ekta Diwas instituted in **2014** by the Government of India to recognise **Sardar Patel's role in unifying India** .
  - It symbolises the ideals of **national integration, peace, and unity in diversity** .
  - It encourages citizens to **reaffirm their commitment** to national integrity and collective strength.
  - The day also serves as a platform to promote the **'Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat (EBSB)'** initiative, announced by PM Modi in **2015** .
- **Statue of Unity:** Inaugurated on **31 st October 2018** at **Kevadia, Gujarat** , the **Statue of Unity** is the **world's tallest statue** at **182 metres** , dedicated to **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel** .
  - It is located on **Sadhu Bet hillock** overlooking the **Narmada River** and the **Sardar Sarovar Dam** , it symbolises national unity and pride.
  - In **2020** , it was recognised among the **"Eight Wonders of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)."**

Bharat Parv 2026

- Organised from **1st–15th November 2026 under the theme 'Shakti of Bharat',** the festival brings together the cultural heritage of various States and Union Territories on a common platform.
- The festival promotes ' **Unity in Diversity', 'Vocal for Local' and 'Culture to Commerce'** , supporting indigenous artisans and products.

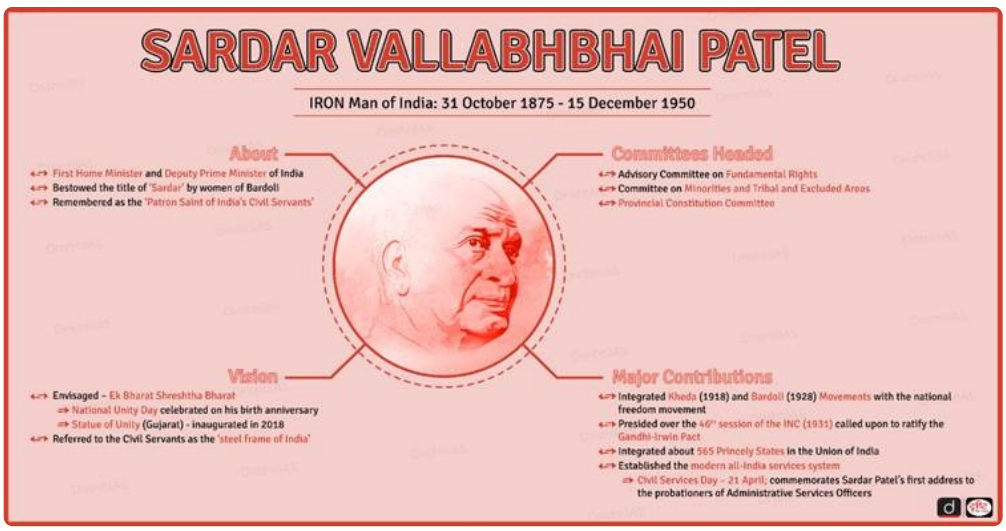
Ekta Prakash Parv 2026

- It showcases **India's cultural heritage, national unity and modern development** through artistic light displays.
- Organised for the **second consecutive year, the festival will continue until 15 January 2027** , promoting the vision of **Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat.**
- The festival features theme-based lighting across **approximately 7.6 km, with indoor zones representing North, East, West and South India** and outdoor installations highlighting regional traditions and cultural landmarks.
- Under the **vision of 'Vikas Bhi, Virasat Bhi'** , the displays also highlight women's empowerment, India's technological advancements, space exploration and the valour of security forces.

What are the Key Facts About Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel?

- **Birth:** Born on **31st October 1875** , in **Nadiad, Gujarat** . His family belonged to the **Lewa Patidar community** .
- **Career:** Completed law studies in England, earning a prize in **Roman Law** , and returned to India as a barrister in **1913** .

- **Title and Legacy:** Popularly known as the **"Iron Man of India"** for his determination and firm approach. He is revered as a **symbol of national unity and resilience** .
- **Political Rise:**
  - **Joining the National Movement:** Patel was inspired by **Mahatma Gandhi** and joined the freedom struggle.
  - **Kheda Satyagraha (1918):** He played a pivotal role in the **Kheda Satyagraha** , demanding land revenue relief for farmers affected by crop failure and agrarian distress.
  - **Bardoli Satyagraha (1928):** Led the resistance during the **Bardoli Satyagraha** against an unjust tax increase, earning him the title **"Sardar"** for his leadership.
- **Role in the Indian National Movement:**
  - **Non-Cooperation and Civil Disobedience:** Actively participated in Gandhian movements, mobilised support for the **Salt Satyagraha** (1930) and faced multiple imprisonments during the freedom struggle.
  - **Presiding Over the Congress:** Presided over the 46th Indian National Congress Session at Karachi (1931), which endorsed the **Gandhi-Irwin Pact** and adopted resolutions on Fundamental Rights and the National Economic Programme.
  - **Quit India Movement (1942):** Patel was arrested and imprisoned during this major phase of India's freedom struggle.
- **Contributions Post-Independence:**
  - **Integration of Princely States:** Spearheaded the integration of 562 princely states into the Indian Union, strengthening national unity and territorial integrity.
    - The **Indian Independence Act, 1947** ended British paramountcy over princely states, creating the possibility for them to remain independent or accede to India or Pakistan.
  - **Reinforcing India’s Civil Services:** Patel was instrumental in establishing the modern **All India Services** , strengthening the administrative framework of the country.
    - Remembered as the **"patron saint of India’s civil servants"** for his contribution to reinforcing the bureaucratic system.
    - **National Civil Services Day** (**21st April**) honors Sardar Patel's 1947 speech, calling civil servants **"the steel frame of India"** and reinforcing their dedication to public service.
  - **Chairmanship and Committee Work:** Led the Advisory Committee on **Fundamental Rights** , **Minorities** , and **Tribal and Excluded Areas** in the Constituent Assembly.



What is Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat (EBSB) Initiative?

- **About:** Launched on **31 st October 2015** , the EBSB initiative seeks to **carry forward Patel's vision of national unity and integration** through cultural, linguistic, and social exchange among States and Union Territories.
- **Key Objectives:** Strengthen **emotional bonds** among citizens across regions.
  - Promote **cultural exchange and linguistic appreciation** between states.
  - Foster **national integration** through structured inter-state partnerships.
  - Highlight India's **diverse art, heritage, and traditions** .
  - Encourage **mutual learning and sharing of best practices** .
- **EBSB Events and Initiatives Promoting Unity:**
  - **State and UT Pairing:** EBSB promotes the idea of "unity in diversity" by pairing different States and Union Territories to strengthen emotional bonds through linguistic, cultural, and educational exchanges.
  - **Bhasha Sangam App:** It is an initiative of the **Ministry of Education under EBSB,** to teach basic sentences of everyday usage in 22 Indian languages, encouraging linguistic inclusion.
  - **Yuva Sangam & EBSB Clubs:** Promote **student exchanges** and inter-state youth engagement to build understanding.
  - **Kashi Tamil Sangamam:** Celebrates the cultural and spiritual bond between **Kashi and Tamil Nadu** , promoting unity through **art, language, and tradition** exchange.
  - **Cultural & Food Festivals:** Enhance inter-regional appreciation and tourism.
  - **Digital Outreach:** Platforms like **My Bharat Portal** and **EBSB Quiz** encourage civic participation and cultural awareness online.
- **Impact:** It extends the spirit of **Rashtriya Ekta Diwas** beyond a single day, transforming it into a **continuous movement for national unity** .
  - With **millions of participants** , it supports initiatives like **Dekho Apna Desh (Tourism)** and indigenous sports promotion, reinforcing **India's collective identity** .

Conclusion

Rashtriya Ekta Diwas goes beyond commemorating Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's contribution to national integration. Initiatives such as **Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat, Bharat Parv and cultural exchanges** seek to transform India's diversity into a source of social cohesion, mutual understanding and collective national identity. Together, they reinforce the vision of **unity in diversity** and strengthen the foundations of an inclusive and integrated India.

> ***Drishti Mains Practice Question***
>
> Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel played a pivotal role in India's political integration, while contemporary initiatives such as Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat seek to strengthen its cultural and social integration. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. When was Rashtriya Ekta Diwas instituted and why is it observed?
Ans: It was instituted in **2014** to commemorate **Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's contribution to national integration** and promote unity, peace and national integrity.

Q2. What is the significance of the Statue of Unity?
Ans: Inaugurated on **31 October 2018** at **Ekta Nagar, Gujarat** , the **182-metre Statue of Unity** is the world's tallest statue and honours Sardar Patel.

Q3. Which major movements were associated with Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel?
Ans: Patel played key roles in the **Kheda Satyagraha (1918)** , **Bardoli Satyagraha (1928)** , **Civil Disobedience Movement** , **Salt Satyagraha (1930)** and **Quit India Movement (1942)** .

Q4. What is Bharat Parv 2026?
Ans: Inaugurated on 30 October 2026 at Ekta Nagar, Bharat Parv 2026 is a cultural festival held from 1–15 November, showcasing regional traditions, handicrafts, cuisines and performing arts under the theme 'Shakti of Bharat'.

Q5. What was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's major contribution after Independence?
Ans: Patel spearheaded the **integration of 562 princely states into the Indian Union** and played an important role in strengthening the **All India Services** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/AMiKUnv4gfM]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. What was the reason for Mahatma Gandhi to organize a satyagraha on behalf of the peasants of Kheda? (2011)

1. The Administration did not suspend the land revenue collection in spite of a drought.
2. The Administration proposed to introduce Permanent Settlement in Gujarat.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 only

(c) Both 1 and 2

(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (a)

Q. For the Karachi Session of Indian National Congress in 1931 presided over by Sardar Patel, who drafted the Resolution on Fundamental Rights and Economic Programme? (2010)

(a) Mahatma Gandhi

(b) Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru

(c) Dr. Rajendra Prasad

(d) Dr. B. R. Ambedkar

Ans: (b)

24th Instalment of PM-KISAN

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Government released the **24th instalment of Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN)** from Banaskantha, Gujarat, transferring approximately ₹18,690 crore in direct financial assistance to over 9.34 crore eligible farmers.

What are the Key Facts About PM-KISAN?

- **About:** Launched on **24th February 2019, the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) is a Central Sector Scheme with 100% funding from the Government of India** to provide income support to eligible landholding farmer families.
  - The scheme became operational retrospectively from 1st December 2018.
- **Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare,** through the Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare.
- **Financial Assistance:** Provides **₹6,000 annually in three equal instalments of ₹2,000** , transferred directly into beneficiaries' Aadhaar-seeded bank accounts through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT).
- **Beneficiary Coverage:** Covers eligible landholding farmer families possessing **cultivable land, subject to specified exclusion criteria** . A farmer family is defined as husband, wife and minor children.
- **Objectives: Supports agricultural input purchases, seasonal cultivation expenses and household income security** , particularly for small and marginal farmers.
- **Implementation:** State and UT Governments identify eligible beneficiaries and verify land ownership and other records, while the Central Government transfers financial assistance through DBT.
- **Eligibility Requirements:** Beneficiaries must complete land record seeding, Aadhaar-bank account linking and electronic **Know Your Customer (e-KYC)** verification.
- **Continuation and Budgetary Allocation:** The **Union Cabinet approved PM-KISAN's continuation from 2026–27 to 2030–31 with an outlay of ₹3.15 lakh crore** , while the **Union Budget 2026–27** allocated ₹63,500 crore to the scheme.
- **Exclusion Criteria: Institutional landholders, present and former holders of constitutional and specified political offices, and serving or retired government and PSU employees (except eligible Group D, Class IV and Multi-Tasking Staff)** are excluded.

- **Income and Professional Exclusions: Income taxpayers, pensioners receiving ₹10,000 or more per month (subject to exceptions),** and practising professionals such as doctors, engineers, lawyers and chartered accountants are also ineligible.
- **Transparency and Accountability:** Beneficiary lists are publicly displayed at the village level, while States/UTs recover payments made to ineligible beneficiaries.
  - As of December 2025, ₹416.75 crore had been recovered from ineligible beneficiaries.
- **Monitoring and Grievance Redressal:** Implementation is monitored through **National, State and District-level Committees** , with national-level review chaired by the Cabinet Secretary.
  - Farmers can submit grievances through the PM-KISAN Portal and the **Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS).**



What are the Key Digital Initiatives Supporting PM-KISAN?

- **PM-KISAN Portal and Mobile Application:**
  - **Unified Digital Platform:** Maintains a centralised beneficiary database, facilitates registration, eligibility verification and monitoring of financial transfers.
  - **Mobile Application:** Launched in **2020** , it enables farmers to self-register, track instalment status and complete electronic Know Your Customer (e-KYC) verification.
  - **Face Authentication:** Introduced in **2023** , it enables farmers to complete e-KYC through facial recognition without requiring OTP or fingerprint verification. The scheme also supports OTP-based and biometric authentication.
- **Kisan-eMitra AI Chatbot:**
  - **About:** Launched in **September 2023** , Kisan-eMitra is an **AI-enabled multilingual chatbot** providing information on PM-KISAN registration, eligibility and payment status.
  - **Technical Support:** Developed with support from **EkStep Foundation and Digital India**

BHASHINI .

- **Key Features:** Offers **24×7 voice- and text-based assistance in 11 languages** , promoting digital inclusion and last-mile access to agricultural welfare services.

- **Aadhaar-Based DBT Infrastructure:**
  - **Identity Verification:** Aadhaar authentication and e-KYC help identify duplicate records and prevent payments to ineligible beneficiaries.
  - **Financial Integration:** Integration with the **Public Financial Management System (PFMS)** and banking networks facilitates secure and transparent fund transfers.
  - **Data-Driven Governance:** Digital records support beneficiary verification, financial monitoring and accountability across States and UTs.

Conclusion

The release of the 24th PM-KISAN instalment **reinforces the role of direct income support in strengthening agricultural livelihoods** and rural household financial security. Improving land-record accuracy, digital accessibility, grievance redressal and beneficiary inclusion, alongside investments in agricultural infrastructure and productivity, will be essential for making farmer welfare more effective and sustainable.

Drishti Mains Practice Question

Direct income support schemes such as PM-KISAN have strengthened India's agricultural welfare architecture. Examine.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is PM-KISAN?
Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) is a Central Sector Scheme launched in February 2019 that provides eligible landholding farmer families with ₹6,000 annually in three instalments.

Q2. How many farmers benefited from the 24th instalment of PM-KISAN?
Approximately 9.34 crore farmers received more than ₹18,690 crore through DBT on 30 October 2026.

Q3. What is the approved financial outlay for PM-KISAN from 2026–27 to 2030–31?
The Union Cabinet approved an outlay of ₹3.15 lakh crore for continuing the scheme during this period.

Q4. What is Kisan-eMitra?
Kisan-eMitra is an AI-powered multilingual chatbot launched in September 2023 to assist farmers with PM-KISAN registration, eligibility and payment-related queries.

Q5. Is PM-KISAN a Central Sector Scheme or Centrally Sponsored Scheme?
PM-KISAN is a Central Sector Scheme, funded entirely by the Government of India. State and UT Governments are responsible for identifying and verifying eligible beneficiaries.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/2OX-mxnTsiY]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions

Prelims

Q. Under the Kisan Credit Card Scheme, short-term credit support is given to farmers for which of the following purposes? [2020]

1. Working capital for maintenance of farm assets
2. Purchase of combine harvesters, tractors and mini trucks
3. Consumption requirements of farm households
4. Post-harvest expenses
5. Construction of family house and setting up of village cold-storage facility

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

a) 1, 2 and 5 only
b) 1, 3 and 4 only
c) 2, 3, 4 and 5 only
d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (b)

Mains

Q. Reforming the government delivery system through the Direct Benefit Transfer Scheme is a progressive step, but it has its limitations too. Comment. **[2022]**

Q. How can the 'Digital India' programme help farmers to improve farm productivity and income? What steps has the Government taken in this regard? **[2015]**

117th Birth Anniversary of Dr. Homi Jehangir Bhabha

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Source: DD

Why in News?

On **30 th October 2026** , the nation commemorated the 117 th birth anniversary of **Dr. Homi Jehangir Bhabha** . His visionary leadership not only established India's atomic energy roadmap but

also laid the foundational infrastructure for India's space, electronics, and fundamental physics research.



Who is Dr. Homi Jehangir Bhabha?

- **Early Life:** Born in Bombay (now Mumbai) into a Parsi family. Bhabha moved to the UK to study Mechanical Engineering at **Cambridge University** , but his true passion lay in theoretical physics.
  - After completing his engineering degree, he pursued physics, earning his doctorate in nuclear physics in 1934.
- **Scientific Collaborations:** During his time in Europe, he worked alongside some of the greatest minds of the 20th century, including **Niels Bohr, Paul Dirac, and Wolfgang Pauli** , immersing himself in the rapidly evolving field of **quantum mechanics.**
- **Major Scientific Contributions (Fundamental Physics):**
  - **Bhabha Scattering:** He derived a quantum mechanical expression for the probability of scattering positrons by electrons, a phenomenon now internationally known as **'Bhabha scattering'** .
  - **Bhabha-Heitler Cascade Theory (1937):** Alongside Walter Heitler, he developed the **cascade theory of cosmic ray showers,** explaining how primary cosmic rays interact with the **Earth's upper atmosphere to produce observable particles at ground level.**
  - **Meson Prediction:** His work on cosmic rays was crucial in predicting the existence of the **meson (a subatomic particle),** which was later confirmed by global experimental physics.
- **Building India’s Institutional Framework:** Dr. Bhabha recognized that self-reliance required indigenous institutions. Returning to India during **World War II,** he worked closely with Prime Minister **Jawaharlal Nehru** to build India's modern scientific infrastructure:
  - **Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR, 1945):** Founded with funding from **the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust** , TIFR was created to generate a critical mass of homegrown scientists in physics, mathematics, and chemistry.
  - **Atomic Energy Commission (AEC, 1948):** Established to formulate India’s nuclear policies, with **Bhabha as its first Chairman.**
  - **Department of Atomic Energy (DAE, 1954):** Created directly under the Prime Minister's Office, securing the strategic autonomy and funding required for nuclear research.
  - **Atomic Energy Establishment, Trombay (AEET, 1954):** A multidisciplinary research center established for the ambitious nuclear program of India.

    - After Dr. Bhabha's tragic death in an air crash in 1966, it was renamed the **Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC)** .
- **Nuclear Power Programme: Dr. Bhabha** formulated India’s visionary **Three-Stage Nuclear Power Programme** .
    - This closed fuel-cycle strategy (**PHWRs → Fast Breeder Reactors → Advanced Heavy Water Reactors**) was designed to achieve long-term energy security by utilizing India’s vast indigenous **Thorium reserves** (found in monazite sands) instead of relying on imported Uranium.
    - Bhabha spearheaded the development of **APSARA** , India’s first research reactor (1 MWt capacity), and drafted the **Atomic Energy Act of 1948** to secure India's strategic autonomy over its nuclear program.
- **Contributions Beyond Nuclear Energy:**
    - **Space Programme:** The **Indian National Committee for Space Research (INCOSPAR)** was established in 1962 under the DAE, largely through the vision of **scientist Dr. Vikram Sarabhai** and with the instrumental support of **DAE director Homi Bhabha** during the tenure of Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru. **INCOSPAR later evolved into ISRO.**
    - **Electronics & Radio Astronomy:** In the 1960s, an electronic committee was set up under the leadership of Dr. Homi Bhabha to promote domestic manufacturing of critical components, laying the groundwork for India’s IT and electronics sector.
    - **Global Diplomacy:** He served as the President of the first **United Nations Conference on the Peaceful Uses of Atomic Energy** in Geneva (1955).
        - Bhabha was a member of the **International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)** 's first Scientific Advisory Committee, constituted in 1958, and also served on its Board of Governors.
- **Strategic Ambiguity:** Bhabha championed the peaceful use of nuclear energy but insisted on developing a latent, indigenous weapons capability. He famously stated that a nuclear deterrent was the only way to safeguard India against global nuclear blackmail.
    - Bhabha's institutional foundations laid the groundwork for India's nuclear programme. Following **China's 1964 nuclear test** , he advocated a weapons capability, eventually leading to **Pokhran-I (1974) and Pokhran-II (Operation Shakti, 1998).**
- **Awards & Recognitions:** Elected as a **Fellow of the Royal Society in 1941** and awarded the **Padma Bhushan in 1954** for his monumental contributions to science and nation-building.
- **Contemporary Relevance:** Bhabha's approach to scientific self-reliance remains relevant amid growing geopolitical competition in emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence.
    - The **India AI Impact Summit 2026** highlighted the importance of strengthening domestic technological capabilities while pursuing international cooperation and inclusive global governance - an approach broadly consistent with Bhabha's vision of combining national scientific capacity with global collaboration.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Who was Dr. Homi Jehangir Bhabha?
Dr. Homi J. Bhabha was an eminent Indian c physicist and institution-builder, widely regarded as the Father of India's Nuclear Programme.

2. What is Bhabha Scattering?
It is the quantum mechanical scattering of electrons and positrons, theoretically described by Homi Bhabha.

3. What was the role of Homi Bhabha in establishing TIFR?
He established the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) in 1945 with support from J.R.D. Tata to promote advanced scientific research.

4. What is the objective of India's Three-Stage Nuclear Power Programme?
It aims to achieve long-term energy security by progressively utilising India's limited uranium resources and vast thorium reserves through a closed fuel cycle.

5. What was Bhabha's contribution to India's space programme?
He established INCOSPAR in 1962 under the Department of Atomic Energy and appointed Vikram Sarabhai to lead it. INCOSPAR later evolved into ISRO.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/MtYaZ7_7co4]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. The fusion energy programme in India has steadily evolved over the past few decades. Mention India's contributions to the international fusion energy project – International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor (ITER). What will be the implications of the success of this project for the future of global energy? **(2025)**

Q. Discuss the work of 'Bose-Einstein Statistics' done by Prof. Satyendra Nath Bose and show how it revolutionized the field of Physics. **(2018)**

SC Declines to Mandate Full Public Disclosure for AIFs and FPIs

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Source: TH

Why in News?

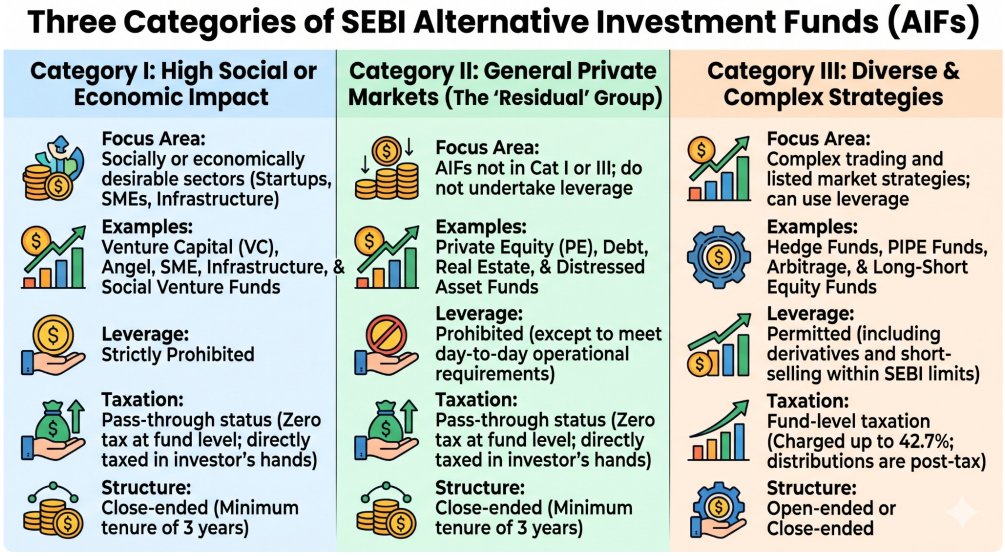
The Supreme Court of India has refused to issue a judicial order directing the **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)** to mandate full public disclosure of the ultimate beneficial owners behind **Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs)** and **Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs),** citing the absence of a supporting legislative framework.

What is the Supreme Court's Ruling on Disclosure of AIFs and FPIs?

- **Opaque Financial Structures:** The petition raised concerns that unlike mutual funds which are heavily regulated under the **SEBI Mutual Fund Regulations, 1996** .
  - **AIFs and FPIs operate under opaque structures** , significantly increasing the risks of **market manipulation, money laundering , and tax evasion** .
- **Exponential Market Growth:** The petition noted that **AIF Assets Under Management (AUM)** reached **Rs 13 lakh crore in 2024** , while registered **FPI Assets Under Custody (AUC)** exceeded **Rs 74 lakh crore in 2025** , vastly overshadowing mutual fund investments.
- **SEBI's Regulatory Autonomy:** Defending the current mechanism, the Solicitor General noted that disclosures are strictly made to the regulator (SEBI) and cited the **Supreme Court’s January 2024 Adani-Hindenburg judgment (*Vishal Tiwari vs Union of India*)** , which established that **constitutional courts possess only limited powers of judicial review over SEBI’s expert regulatory domain** .
- **Article 32 and Separation of Powers:** The Court stated that the appropriateness of a Member of Parliament filing a Public Interest Litigation under **Article 32 (Right to Constitutional Remedies)** , emphasizing that such systemic financial transparency issues should ideally be debated and legislated on the floor of the Parliament.

What is an Alternative Investment Fund (AIF)?

- **About:** An AIF is a privately pooled investment vehicle established in India that **collects capital from sophisticated investors** (both domestic and foreign) to invest according to a pre-defined strategy.
- **Regulation:** AIFs are regulated by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) under the **SEBI (Alternative Investment Funds) Regulations, 2012.**
- **Target Asset Classes:** These funds go beyond conventional investments like standard mutual funds to invest in alternative assets such as private equity, venture capital, start-ups, real estate, infrastructure, commodities, and private credit.
- **Target Audience:** AIFs cater to sophisticated investors, including High-Net-Worth Individuals (HNIs), family offices, institutional investors, and corporations, who have a high-risk appetite and a long-term investment horizon.
- **Minimum Investment:** The minimum investment amount for most AIF investors is generally Rs 1 crore.
  - However, directors and specified employees of an AIF or its manager can invest a minimum of Rs 25 lakh.
- **Fund Structure:** An AIF can be **constituted as a trust, a company, a Limited Liability Partnership (LLP)** , or a corporate body.



Foreign Portfolio Investment (FPI)

- **FPI** refers to passive investments by foreign entities in a country's financial assets, such as stocks and bonds, aimed at short-term capital appreciation rather than acquiring business control (which falls under **Foreign Direct Investment**).
- **The 10% Limit:** Under the Foreign Exchange Management (Non-debt Instruments) Rules, 2019 (NDI Rules), an FPI, along with its investor group, must hold less than 10% of an Indian company's paid-up equity capital on a fully diluted basis.
  - Breaching this limit requires the investor to either divest its holdings or reclassify the investment as FDI
- **FPI vs. FII:** **Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs)** such as pension funds, mutual funds, and insurance companies are a subset of FPIs.
  - While FPI encompasses all foreign financial investments (including those by individuals), FII refers strictly to structured, institutional entities.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is an Alternative Investment Fund (AIF)?
An AIF is a privately pooled investment vehicle established in India, regulated by SEBI under the SEBI (Alternative Investment Funds) Regulations, 2012, investing in alternative asset classes such as private equity, venture capital and real estate.

2. What are the three categories of AIFs under SEBI regulations?
Category I: Venture Capital, Angel, SME and Infrastructure Funds.

Category II: Private Equity, Debt and Real Estate Funds.

Category III: Hedge Funds and funds employing complex trading strategies.

3. What is Foreign Portfolio Investment (FPI), and how does it differ from FDI?
FPI involves investment in financial assets such as stocks and bonds without acquiring management control, whereas FDI involves a lasting interest and significant influence or control over an enterprise.

4. What is the minimum investment requirement for AIFs in India?
The general minimum investment is ₹1 crore, while directors, managers and specified employees of an AIF can invest a minimum of ₹25 lakh, subject to applicable SEBI conditions.

5. What is the significance of the Supreme Court's ruling on AIFs and FPIs?
The Court declined to mandate public disclosure of ultimate beneficial owners without a supporting legislative framework, highlighting the importance of separation of powers and SEBI's regulatory autonomy.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/cYOHv0yEaP0]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. With reference to investments, consider the following: (2025)

1. Bonds
2. Hedge Funds
3. Stock
4. Venture Capital

How many of the above are treated as Alternative Investment Funds?

a) Only one

b) Only two

c) Only three

d) All the four

Ans:(b)

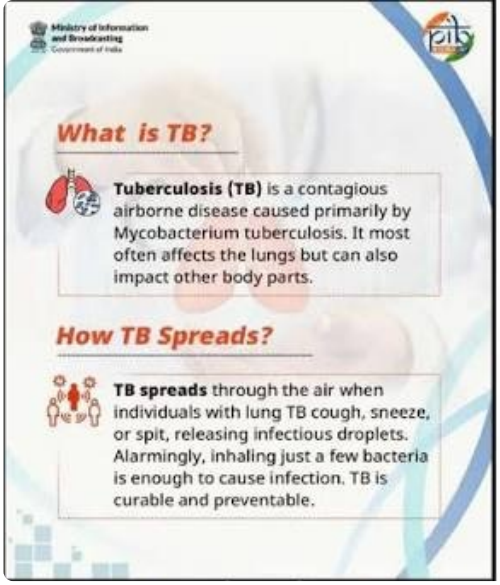
India’s Rejection of the BPaL Patent

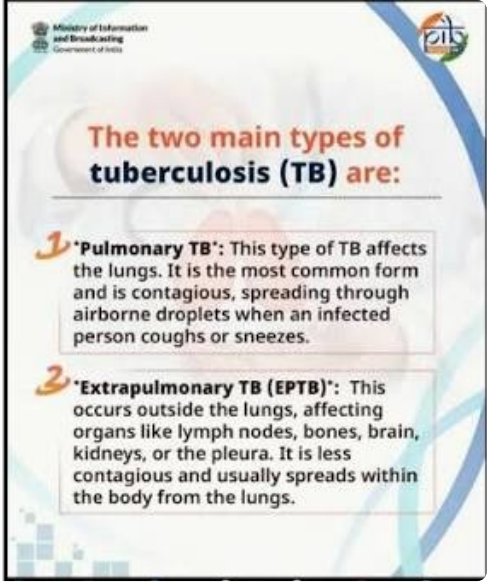
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Source: IE

The **Indian Patent Office** rejected a patent application filed by the US-based Global Alliance for TB Drug Development (TB Alliance) for a **drug-resistant tuberculosis (MDR-TB) treatment combination known as the BPaL regimen.**

- **The BPaL and BPaLM Regimens: BPaL is a six-month, all-oral treatment regimen** recommended by the **World Health Organization (WHO)** for drug-resistant TB, comprising **bedaquiline, pretomanid, and linezolid** .
  - The **BPaLM variant** , which adds **moxifloxacin** , boasts an **89% treatment success rate** , vastly outperforming the 52-75% success rate of standard, longer regimens that often require painful injections.
- **India's TB Burden:** Addressing this is critical as **India accounts for nearly 25% of all global TB cases** , recording an incidence rate of **187 cases per 100,000 people in 2024** .
  - India missed its ambitious 2025 target to **eliminate Tuberculosis under the National Tuberculosis Elimination Programme (NTEP)** . However, despite falling short of total elimination, the country made significant strides by reducing its **TB incidence rate by 21% between 2015 and 2024.**
- **Key Grounds for Patent Rejection:** Civil society organizations filed pre-grant oppositions against the application under **Section 25(1) of the Patents Act, 1970** , arguing that clinical trials dating from 2015 had already disclosed the medicines in combination.
  - The Patent Controller cited a **lack of novelty, absence of an inventive step** , and **insufficient disclosure,** invoking the following statutory frameworks:
    - **Section 3(d):** Restricts patents on new forms of known substances unless they demonstrate significantly enhanced efficacy, acting as a crucial safeguard against **"evergreening" (extending patent protection through minor modifications).**
    - **Section 3(e):** Excludes a mere admixture of known substances from patentability.
    - **Section 3(i):** Excludes methods of treating human beings from patentability.
- **Economic Impact and Public Health:** Eliminating the patent barrier allows **generic manufacturers to produce the drugs** , fostering competition and reducing prices.
  - This allows the government to procure cheaper medicines for the **NTEP** effectively expanding the program's reach within the same budget.
  - Aligns with the **Right to Health under Article 21,** with the Supreme Court in **Parmanand Katara v. Union of India (1989)** emphasising the State's duty to protect human life.
- **Regulatory Independence:** Patent rejection does not automatically authorize generic sales; manufacturers still require marketing approvals from the **Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO)** and must align with national treatment guidelines and quality checks.





Read more: **Towards a TB-Free India**

National Social Security Boards for Unorganised and Gig Workers

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Source: TH

The Union Labour Ministry has notified the constitution of the **National Social Security Board for Unorganised Workers** and the **National Social Security Board for Gig & Platform Workers** .

- **Statutory Framework:** The boards are established under the statutory framework of the **Code on Social Security, 2020** marking a significant policy shift toward formalizing welfare for gig and platform professionals.
- **Board Composition:** The National Social Security Board for Unorganised Workers comprises **40 members** , while the National Social Security Board for Gig & Platform Workers consists of **22 members** .
- **Leadership Structure:** The **Union Minister for Labour and Employment acts as the Chairman** of both boards, with the **Union Labour Secretary serving as the Vice-Chairman** .
- **Diverse Representation:** Members include representatives from the Central and specific State governments, worker unions, prominent aggregator companies (such as Swiggy, Zomato, Zepto, Rapido, Urban Company), and civil society organizations.
- **Core Mandate & Functions:** To **design, monitor, and recommend** targeted welfare schemes for different sections of **unorganised, gig, and platform workers.**

- To advise the Union Government on the **administration of the Social Security Code** .
- To **review expenditure** from the social security funds and monitor record-keeping functions at the State level.

- **Operational Protocol:** Both boards are mandated to **meet at least thrice a year** under rules prescribed by the Union government under Code on Social Security, 2020.
- **Challenges & Criticisms:** Trade unions have raised concerns regarding the composition of the boards, **alleging a tilt towards the Union Government** and employer organizations, while worker federations emphasize that success relies entirely on actual benefit delivery to workers.
- **Significance:** The initiative strengthens India's institutional framework for extending social security to an expanding gig workforce, projected by **NITI Aayog to reach 2.35 crore by 2029–30.**

Gig, Platform, and Unorganised Workers (As per Code on Social Security, 2020)

- **Gig Worker:** A person who performs work or participates in a work arrangement and earns from such activities **outside of a traditional employer-employee relationship** .
- **Platform Worker:** A person engaged in or undertaking platform work. (Platform work refers to a work arrangement outside of a traditional employer-employee relationship in which organizations or individuals use an **online algorithmic matching platform** or app to solve specific problems or provide specific services).
- **Unorganised Worker:** A home-based worker, self-employed worker, or a wage worker in the unorganised sector, including a worker in the organized sector who is not covered by mainstream industrial legislations like the **Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.**

Read more: **Strengthening India's Gig Economy**

Manisha Bhanwala Becomes 1st Indian Woman Wrestling World Champion

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Source: DD

Manisha Bhanwala became the **first Indian woman to win a gold medal at the Senior World Wrestling Championships,** defeating **Abigail Elizabeth Nette (USA) 8–6 in the 59 kg** final at Astana, Kazakhstan. She became India's second senior **World Wrestling Champion after Sushil Kumar (66 kg gold in 2010).**

- **Non-Olympic Category:** The **59 kg category is a non-Olympic weight class** , but her victory marks a major milestone in **Indian women's wrestling** .
- **Record Medal Haul:** India registered its **best-ever performance in women's wrestling at the Championships** , securing four medals (one gold, two silver and one bronze).
  - **Neelam Sirohi (50 kg) and Kajal Dhochak (76 kg)** won silver medals in Olympic weight categories, while **Tanu Sharma (72 kg)** secured bronze.
- **Earlier Milestone: Anshu Malik** was previously the only Indian woman to reach a World Championships final, winning **silver in 57 kg in 2021** . **Vinesh Phogat** and **Antim Panghal** had previously won bronze medals.
- **World Wrestling Championships:** Organised by **United World Wrestling (UWW)** , the **sport's international governing body,** the Championships feature **men's freestyle, women's freestyle and Greco-Roman wrestling.**



Read More: Under-20 National Wrestling Championship